

RBC

Here are tailored responses for your questions:

1. What have you done to increase the innovative capacity of your organization, business, or community?

In 2021 I was a co-founder in the development of 807 Food Co-operative, a grassroots organization dedicated to increasing collaborations in agri-food. In 2022 we launched with Local Food and Farms Co-op the Dryden Food Hub Project, a grassroots pilot initiative later supported by the Ontario Co-operative Association. This project is dedicated to enhancing local food production and cultivating collaborations among diverse stakeholders, including local food operations and community partners.

We have established collaborative platforms like Local Line, that facilitate shared sales and inventory, significantly increasing our capacity for innovation. One key focus is reducing barriers for new agrifood startups, especially those led by women, by providing them with essential resources, facilities, equipment, and support through our Food Hub Programs.

Additionally, our strategic plan includes engagement with partners like PACE and the Northwestern Ontario Innovation Centre, enabling us to leverage a wide range of expertise to develop creative solutions for food security. This collaborative approach not only fosters innovation but also strengthens our community's resilience and capacity to adapt to future challenges.

2. Have you engaged your community and/or organization by enrolling all stakeholders in a new vision of success? Have you embraced change as a new opportunity to innovate and create value? Have you engaged your community, business or organization in dialogues that inspire renewed commitment and encourage the contribution of new, innovative opportunities?

Yes, as the Director of 807 Food Co-operative, I have actively engaged our community and stakeholders in a new vision of success that emphasizes collaboration and innovation. Since 2021, our initiatives have generated over \$350,000 in local food sales through diverse member pilot programs, such as Vegetable Boxes, Meat Boxes, and Dairy Subscriptions. A study conducted in Temiskaming revealed that for every dollar spent at a farm gate, there is an average increase of up to 230% in the wider local economy. Consequently, it is estimated that our project has contributed approximately \$1,155,000 to the local economy over its lifecycle.

Our programs specifically empower women by offering business incubation initiatives and training opportunities for underemployed women, thereby fostering agri-food connections in Northwestern Ontario. This focus has created positive economic and social ripples throughout our community.

In the past year, we successfully highlighted the environmental impact of local food sales and regenerative agriculture practices through various initiatives. We partnered with local businesses to co-host events and develop joint marketing materials that promoted our shared commitment to sustainability. Our social media campaign, “Burger Bonanza,” encouraged customers to share their local food experiences at participating restaurants featuring locally sourced ingredients, fostering a vibrant community dialogue around environmental stewardship. By embracing change as an opportunity to innovate and create value, we have inspired renewed commitment and engagement within our community.

3. As a leader have you created and fostered a culture of on-going, never-ending change in your organization, community or business? Have you ensured that your organization continually learns, adapts, evolves, and improves?

As a leader in the local food movement, I have actively fostered a culture of ongoing growth and adaptation within our organization. By supporting start up and growth projects and infrastructure for front line producers and processors, we’ve established an environment where collaboration is integral to our operations. Implementing systems & software for sales and marketing allows us to respond dynamically to community needs and market trends, ensuring our organization remains relevant and effective.

We have launched underemployment programs through member businesses, receiving heartfelt testimonials from participants and support staff that highlight significant improvements in confidence and quality of life for these women and youth with disabilities. These outcomes clearly demonstrate the project’s effectiveness in driving meaningful change and enhancing the well-being of individuals within our community.

Looking ahead, I am committed to enhancing food security through innovative community engagement and the creation of the Northwestern Ontario Food Hub Network Project, which connects food operations between Thunder Bay, Sioux Lookout, and Dryden. By deepening our partnerships and facilitating shared distribution among communities, we aim to ensure that everyone has access to fresh, locally produced food. Together, we can transform the way food is produced and shared, making significant strides toward a resilient and self-sufficient

community.
